

# JOINTS AND FLEXIBILITY

While a certain degree of flexibility is important in accomplishing many asanas and completing daily activities, it's crucial to understand your body and know your limits so you can avoid injury and look after your joints. If you are very flexible, it may be best to focus on strengthening asanas.

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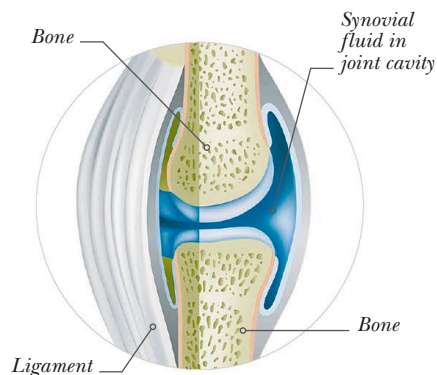
Most of the  
**360**  
joints in the body  
are synovial, or  
free-moving.

Q CAN I DO YOGA IF I'M NOT FLEXIBLE?

**Yes. Yoga has** been widely shown to increase flexibility, so a lack of flexibility only gives you more reason to practice. If you have limited range of motion (ROM) in a pose because your muscles are tight or you are recovering from an injury, it can be helpful to visualize your body moving deeper into the pose. Research suggests that this creates a neural map, sending signals to the muscles which leads to increased ROM. Similarly, research has found that visualizing yourself doing a pose and getting stronger can measurably strengthen your muscles, even without moving.

Q WHY DO MY JOINTS “POP”?

**Most joints have** synovial fluid between the bones, which contains dissolved gas molecules. Creating more space in the joint—for example, by pulling your thumb—pulls gases out of the fluid, similar to how CO<sub>2</sub> bubbles fizz out of carbonated drinks when you open the bottle. The gases redissolve into the fluid, and can be “popped” again after 20–30 minutes. There is no evidence to suggest this causes arthritis, but it may make your joints larger. If your joints pop with no wait, the joint structures may be rubbing against each other. This could slowly damage the joint structures.



SYNOVIAL JOINT